

EDUCATIONPLUS

GET THE EDGE Follow us facebook.com/thehindu x.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

Y.R.M. Rao

Every year, higher education institutions invest significant effort in attracting students through advertisements, outreach programmes, educational fairs, and admission campaigns. Many expect faculty members to participate in admission-related and various administrative activities that extend beyond their core academic roles. While student enrolment and institutional sustainability are undeniably important, the increasing diversion of faculty time towards non-academic functions often leaves limited scope for meaningful engagement in research, innovation, and scholarly pursuits.

Consequently, many institutions continue to be evaluated primarily on examination results, placements, and admissions rather than on their contribution to knowledge creation. In an era driven by innovation and global competitiveness, this calls for a re-examination of institutional priorities. The true strength of a higher education institution lies not merely in the number of students it admits or graduates, but in its ability to generate new knowledge, solve real-world problems, and contribute to societal progress through sustained research and innovation.

As India aspires to emerge as a global knowledge hub, institutions must

Beyond results and admissions

Higher education institutions require a clear academic vision supported by four interconnected pillars: research publications, scholarly books, patents, and funded research projects



move beyond their traditional role as centres of instruction and evolve into centres of discovery, innovation, and intellectual leadership. This transformation requires a clear academic vision supported by four interconnected pillars: research publications, scholarly books, patents, and funded research projects. Together, they strengthen the profile of individual faculty members while elevating the institution's reputation and impact.

Research: The publication of quality research papers, which are the most visible expression of scholarly activity and intellectual contribution, enables faculty members to share new findings, challenge existing assumptions, and advance knowledge within their disciplines. Publications in reputed journals enhance academic visibility, encourage collaboration, and establish credibility among peers. More importantly, research-active faculty members bring fresh perspectives into the classroom, ensuring that students learn not only established concepts but also emerging developments shaping their fields. This transforms teaching from the transmission of existing knowledge into an engagement with new knowledge.

Publications: Books and scholarly works represent a deeper and more comprehensive engagement with a subject than is often possible through articles alone. They allow edu-

cators to synthesise knowledge, document experiences, and present original insights in a structured manner. Scholarly writing contributes to the academic ecosystem by creating valuable resources for students, researchers, and professionals. Faculty members who author books help build intellectual capital that continues to influence learning long after individual lectures have ended.

Innovation: Research achieves its fullest value when it moves beyond theory and finds practical application. Patents recognise originality and demonstrate the researchers' ability to transform ideas into useful products, processes, or technologies. They serve as evidence that academic work can address industrial, technological, and societal challenges. Institutions that promote innovation and patent generation cultivate a culture of creativity, problem-solving, and entrepreneurship, which are increasingly essential in the modern knowledge economy. Patents also strengthen the links between academia and industry, ensuring that research outcomes contribute directly to economic and social development.

Funded research projects: Securing grants from government agencies, industries, and international organisations testifies to the quality and relevance of a researcher's ideas. Funded projects provide resources to investigate com-

plex problems, develop infrastructure, foster interdisciplinary collaboration, and engage students in meaningful research experiences. They often lead to a cycle of publications, patents, consultancy opportunities, and societal impact. Institutions with strong research funding portfolios are generally better positioned to contribute to national priorities and global academic discourse.

The responsibility to strengthen these four pillars does not rest solely with faculty members. Management and academic administrators must create enabling environments through supportive policies, research infrastructure, incentives, reduced procedural barriers, and a culture that values scholarly achievement. Faculty members, in turn, must view research not as an additional obligation but as an integral component of their academic identity. When these efforts converge, institutions become more than centres of teaching; they become centres of knowledge creation and innovation. Faculty members are appointed not just to teach existing knowledge but also to create new knowledge; institutions that recognise this distinction are the ones that ultimately lead rather than follow.

The writer is an academic, administrator, researcher, and author with over four decades of experience in Engineering education and institutional development.

SCHOLARSHIPS

LIC Golden Jubilee Scholarships
Offered by the LIC Golden Jubilee Foundation.
Eligibility: Students who have secured at least 60% in Classes 10 and 12 in the 2023-24 to 2025-26 academic years. For the General Scholarship, applicants must be in the first year of one of the listed academic programmes in 2026-27. For the Special Scholarship, applicants must be in the first year of intermediate, vocational or diploma courses. Annual family income must not exceed ₹450,000.
Rewards: Up to ₹50,000.
Application: Online
Deadline: September 30
www.b4s.in/edge/LICCI

Central Sector Scheme of Scholarship for College and University Students
Offered by the Ministry of Education, Government of India.
Eligibility: Indian nationals with minimum 80% in Class 12 from a recognised institution who are enrolled in a professional programme and have an annual family income not exceeding ₹450,000.
Rewards: ₹20,000/year
Application: Online
Deadline: September 30
www.b4s.in/edge/CSSS3

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman
I am 25 with a Bachelor's in Anthropology and a Master's in English Literature, but still struggling to find a job. Should I pursue short-term courses in AI, Data Analytics or Cybersecurity without a technical background, or another Master's abroad in Anthropology or a related field? Sanskar

Dear Sanskar,

It must be frustrating to hold two solid degrees and not be employed yet! You probably need to make your application more marketable.

Moving into tech or corporate domains using short-term courses is one strategy, but you must choose the right niche.

For Data Analytics, focus on Excel, SQL, and Power BI/Tableau. AI (Prompt Engineering and AI Operations) is also great. Companies need people with exceptional language skills to engineer prompts, train AI models on tone/nuance, and evaluate conversational AI output. Cybersecurity is highly technical. Without a technical background, the learning curve is steep.

Explore UX Research. The core job is to interview users, observe behaviours, and write clear product recommendations. In around six months, you can learn Figma, Usability Testing and Information Architecture.

Consider studying abroad for a specific purpose and not to get a generic academic degree. Avoid M.A. Literature/Anthropology unless you are looking for an academic or research-oriented career.

Consider applied interdisciplinary degrees such as Digital Anthropology, HCI, or Medical Anthropology/Global Health

Focus on the role
Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

in the U.K. (UCL, Manchester or Sussex); Interactive Digital Media or Public Culture Studies in Ireland (Trinity College Dublin or UCD); or Intercultural Communication or Cognitive Science in Germany.

I have completed BBA LL.B. and have three years of litigation experience. I am pursuing a Master's in Public Policy, Law and Governance. What jobs or internships should I target for a well-paid job with opportunities to work internationally? Anshula

Dear Anshula,

To move into the international domain, transition from traditional litigation and move towards the intersection of tech, trade, compliance, and international law.

Policy and AI Governance involves data privacy, AI regulation, and content moderation across jurisdiction. International Trade and Competition Law involves cross-border transactions, mergers, trade disputes and global competition compliance. ESG and Climate Policy roles at MNCs involve supply-chain audits, carbon credits and international climate compliance.

Do not be a generalist. Pick one domain and align your projects, research and internships accordingly. For Public Policy and Government Relations, consider Google, Microsoft, Amazon, or Reliance.

For International Trade/Policy, explore law firms such as Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas, Khaitan & Co and Trilegal. Think tanks such as Vidhi, ORF and CPR offer policy research roles, while EY, Deloitte, PwC, KPMG,

McKinsey and BCG offer government and risk advisory opportunities.

I am pursuing a certificate course in Urdu and plan to be a language translator. What are my career options? Sahil

Dear Sahil,

To build a career as a language translator, ensure your English-to-Urdu or Hindi-to-Urdu skills are equally strong. Most online jobs require translating source text from English. Master Computer-Assisted Translation (CAT) tools such as SDL Trados, MemoQ, or Smartcat.

Create profiles on Upwork, Freelancer, and ProZ and upload mock translations of legal contracts, medical brochures, or creative subtitles to showcase your expertise.

Get certified by recognised professional bodies and national translation guilds. Your career options span traditional media, global corporate ecosystems, and the tech landscape of 2026.

Look at technical and corporate roles such as AI Training and Language Alignment Specialist. Tech companies and AI data firms recruit regional language experts to train Large Language Models (LLMs).

Localisation specialist roles adapt apps, software interfaces, websites, and map data for cultural appropriateness in Urdu. Remote medical or legal interpreters work through platforms such as Jeniee or Focus Interpreting, providing linguistic support between English-speaking professionals and Urdu-speaking clients.

Explore media,

entertainment and publishing industries for subtitling and dubbing roles in the OTT space. Urdu news portals also need translators for global press releases, wire copy, and international reports. Across government and intergovernmental sectors, explore departments, ministries, and embassies that hire translators for bilateral documentation and trade communications. The UAE, Saudi Arabia, and Qatar offer roles across English, Arabic, and Urdu.

I have finished Class 12 and am interested in a job in the defence forces. I am also good at football. Will sports certificates from college help me get in or do I have to work on my physical and exam preparations? Devika

Dear Devika,

For women, entry as an officer to the Defence Forces is through the National Defence Academy (NDA) written exam after Class 12 or the Officers Training Academy (OTA) via the CDS exam after graduation. These are standard, well-structured paths.

While sports achievements can help in the Services Selection Board (SSB) interview, the exams are mandatory and there is no exemption on the basis of sports certificates.

Outstanding state, national, or international sports certificates let you apply for direct non-commissioned officer ranks like soldier/JCO roles like Havildar or Naib Subedar under the Indian Army sports quota.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge



Code with care
Can Indian universities close the AI ethics gap?

Shobhit Mathur

Given the pace at which Artificial Intelligence (AI) is reshaping industry, education, and public life, universities in India are racing to prepare students for an AI-driven economy. Yet, technical training alone will not suffice. AI education also needs to factor in an ethical code of conduct for its proper implementation and use.

India's universities have built genuine technical capacity. The IITs and IIMs command global respect and the National Education Policy's (NEP 2020) push for interdisciplinary learning is a meaningful signal. AI centres are opening, partnerships multiplying, and enrolment rising. But the curriculum tells a

different story. Ethics, when it appears at all, tends to be a single elective in later years of graduation. It is treated as a compliance checkbox rather than a lens for decision-making.

This matters because the problems AI creates are not primarily technical. A language model trained on urban data performs poorly in regional dialects. A credit-scoring algorithm would deny loans to farmers because their transaction patterns look anomalous to a system designed around salaried employment. These are engineering failures with social roots and fixing them requires people who understand both. An engineer who understands technology without understanding society is only

partially educated. In high-stakes decisions, that gap becomes dangerous.

What can be done

Three changes would shift this. First, ethics must be embedded in technical courses, not appended to them. When a student designs a recommendation algorithm, they should simultaneously analyse its incentive structures and potential for manipulation, not in a separate classroom, but in the same project brief.

Second, judgment is built through experience, not instruction. Case studies, public-interest internships, and capstone projects tied to real problems – such as healthcare access in tier-3 cities or vernacular tools for government services – teach students

to navigate competing values in ways that a memorised code of ethics simply cannot.

Third, India has a specific opportunity that its universities have not fully seized. The country's scale, diversity, and resource constraints make it a natural testing ground for inclusive AI. A university training students to build affordable diagnostic tools for primary health centres or crop-advisory systems in a dozen languages is not simply preparing graduates for employment. It is building a different kind of global standing; one grounded in solving problems that wealthier markets have no financial reason to address.

The harder question is whether institutions have the incentive to act. Rankings reward research output and placement rates. Ethics modules improve neither. For universities to change course, employer expectations and government accreditation standards need to move together.

India has a young population and a growing AI sector. Whether that combination produces genuine leaders or highly skilled operators depends on decisions being made right now: inside syllabus committees, research labs, and boardrooms. Those decisions are not predetermined; they remain available.

The writer is Vice Chancellor, Rishihood University.

SAVE THE DATE

Money matters
Bitget has partnered with UNICEF to create an online financial literacy module for the Game Changers Coalition curriculum. Developed as an interactive self-paced online course, the module uses short videos, visual content, and quizzes to cover supply and demand,

budgeting, credit, loans, interest rates, and blockchain basics. The programme is designed primarily for young learners and is accessible free of charge through Agora, UNICEF's learning platform. Participants who complete the course will receive a certificate. For more details about the course, visit <https://tinyurl.com/476yhafc>

Yuva Yodha
Schneider Electric has launched Yuva Yodha, a national tech hackathon to create innovative, practical, and scalable solutions for India's growing energy and sustainability needs across four key areas critical to India's growth and energy transition: Sustainable Agriculture, Smart Buildings, Grid Reliability and

Renewable Intermittency, and Smart Manufacturing
Eligibility: Indian citizens or residents who are full-time students of UG or PG STEM programmes. Participants can compete individually or in teams of up to four members.
Deadline: October 4
For more details about the initiative and to register, visit yuvayodhatech.com

